day's India, with the government of the day and its industrialist allies cast as the rule-bending warriors.

This was not the Rahul of old, the one who occasionally fumbled through speeches and shied away from confrontation. This was a man transformed. The rigours of two yatras across the length and breadth of India, the numerical strength of the Opposition alliance and the results of 2024 Lok Sabha election, which left the ruling BJP short of the majority mark, have added a new sense of purpose to Rahul's political journey. Often criticised for not having a coherent discourse, he has learned the art of storytelling, wielding it as deftly as any

51%

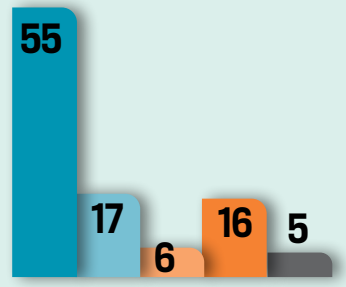
of the respondents rate Rahul Gandhi's performance as Leader of the Opposition good or outstanding

weapon in his new political arsenal.

The shift in approach did not happen overnight. In fact, it was born out of necessity, out of the harsh lessons learned from years of failure and the ridicule associated with it. His critics had long painted him as a reluctant leader, someone who bore the weight of his family's legacy without the conviction to carry it forward. But in recent months, Rahul has begun to rewrite that narrative—both for himself and for the Congress party.

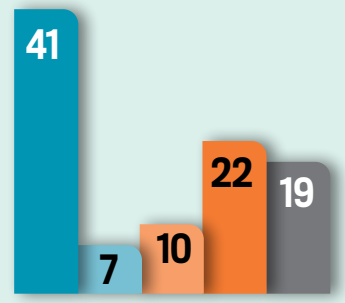
Since taking on the mantle of Leader of the Opposition in the 18th Lok Sabha, Rahul has demonstrated an uncharacteristic commitment to his role, transforming his image from a part-time politician to a 24x7 leader. His dedication to the intricacies of parliamentary proceedings is evident. No longer content to merely react, Rahul now meticulously crafts his speeches, anticipates criticisms and adjusts his strategies with a deftness that speaks of his growing maturity as a politician.

Q. Between Rahul and Priyanka Gandhi, who is the better politician?



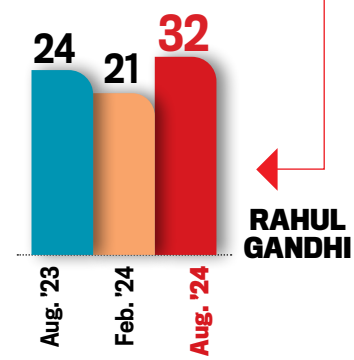
Priyanka may be a beginner, but she's still got a headstart

Q. How do you see Priyanka Gandhi's entry into electoral politics?



Rahul's sister has an appeal that is not lost on the electorate





The countrywide *padayatras* and his Lok Sabha performance have made Rahul a clear favourite

ADAPTING TO GROW

Take, for instance, his inaugural speech in the current Lok Sabha; Rahul sought to carve out a distinct ideological space for himself and his party by drawing a line between the BJP's brand of Hinduism and the philosophy he believes underpins true Hinduism. He accused the BJP of propagating